

ANI

OPEN FIELD
Congress leader Rahul Gandhi with Chhattisgarh chief minister Bhupesh Baghel and other leaders during their visit to farms at Kathiya, near Raipur, Oct. 29

Going by what had been sowed last season in the *bighas* that make up Indian politics, one would have expected a full harvest of Mandal by now—waving in the fields, ready to be reaped in time for the voting. But one does not see caste as the main cash crop in the four big assembly elections this month. What else, then? If you missed all the party proclamations that scream it out, a set of visual clues came early in the morning on October 29, when Congress leader Rahul Gandhi could be spotted wading into waist-high paddies at Kathiya village, near Chhattisgarh's capital Raipur. Sickle in hand and farmhand-style *safa* around his head, he was immersed in a light-hearted lec-dem from labourers busy at the harvest. Happy, farm-fresh images were soon buzzing on his social media timelines. All that bucolic imagery and Chhattisgarhi charm spoke a truth that often tends to get overlooked: the biggest caste in India is still that of the farmer.

Why does this age-old occupational profile—and the needs of this community—often trump caste? Firstly, because defining voters in terms of this economic category has a cohesive effect, rather than a fragmenting one. The social blocs that make up the Other Backward Classes are often in competition with each other at the ground level, so stoking ambitions gets a bit complicated. If the idea is to win everyone's affections, parties must speak to universal needs. And even in the India of 2023, nothing puts all the tiles of the mosaic together like agriculture. Almost every caste is connected to the land and tilling. In a segment that lives on risk and financial insecurity, the promise of state support is relevant to all. No wonder, then, that after two decades of relative neglect in the post-liberalisation years, politics is again mapped on to that primary reality. And that all party manifestos look like sellers' wagons riding into a village haat, spilling over with guarantees, each claiming to be a better guardian of the farm sector.

By a coincidence, this is especially an imperative in these polls. Take a drone's eye view of the economies of Chhattisgarh, Madhya Pradesh, Rajasthan and Telangana. What you see is a vast patchwork of farmlands, interspersed only occasionally by other businesses. A recent NABARD study counted 63.3 per cent households in Rajasthan, 57.7 per cent in MP, 55 per cent in Chhattisgarh and 47.3 per cent in Telangana as dependent on farming. Another 10-15 per cent in all are linked to allied sectors. That means, cumulatively, nearly 60 per cent of the workforce in these states is linked to farming. They punch even above that weight nationally. Official data shows 41.1 per cent of the beneficiaries of central schemes like PM-KISAN are in these four states alone. They have also seen the farm sector growing by 5.2-6.1 per cent from 2013-14 to 2022-23, exceeding the all-India average of 3.9 per cent.

Chhattisgarhi Thaali

With the inherent growth adding to the aspirations, and the challenges, this is not a sector any political party can afford to ignore. No party can be accused of doing that, of course. Chhattisgarh, which saw a 65 per cent turnout in its first phase of polling on November 7 and votes again 10 days later, showcases the competition for the farm vote. Hours after his *krishi darshan* at Kathiya, Rahul was reiterating on social media the five signature pro-farm policies the Bhupesh Baghel government wears proudly on its sleeve: the generous Rs 2,650 minimum support price (MSP) per quintal of paddy; Rs 23,000 crore input subsidy to 2.6 million farmers; Rs 10,000 crore worth loans waived for 1.9 million farmers; electricity bills cut by half; and Rs 7,000 per year to 500,000 farmers. Soon, the generosity was swelling like a ripening crop on all sides. Within days, in Kabirdham district, Rahul promised an increase in the MSP to Rs 3,000 per quintal, along

55%
Average share of households directly dependent on farming in the four big poll-bound states

41%
of all beneficiaries of central schemes like PM-KISAN are in these four states